

3.0 SLEEPING

How, where and how much children sleep is a learned skill. Sleep needs and disturbances change as they grow. Sleep is one of the top concerns with infants and toddlers. Sleep deprivation is beginning in infancy. Without enough sleep children may be fussy, accident-prone or may have difficulty learning. It is an emotional issue, especially if adults are also sleep deprived. It is essential that caregivers and families keep each other abreast of any sleeping issues that may arise.

- Children may have difficulty sleeping due to physical or medical reasons (e.g., teething, ear infections, coughing).
- Temperamental traits such as sensitivity to strange situations, high or low levels of activity, difficulty settling, or not tiring easily influence children's sleeping patterns.
- Fears, anxiety and dreams, especially during periods of major developmental changes like getting ready to walk or going through separation anxiety, may affect children's sleep.
- Too much noise and/or light, schedules that are not in tune with the children's rhythms, changes in regular, familiar schedules, and adult tension are also factors that may affect children's sleeping patterns.
- While many children get on a regular sleep cycle and sleep through the night by 4-6 months of age, others are more irregular.
- Sleeping arrangements vary from family to family.
- Adults often worry that the use of pacifiers may create a bad habit. It is possible, but it is easier to quit than the thumb. Some children may have a need to suck that goes beyond nutritional needs. Toddlers, for example, may use it as a security object. When a pacifier is kept in the crib or car seat and used only at specific times, children learn to associate it with certain activities.
- Babies need to sleep on their backs; their faces or heads should never be covered with sheets or blankets, as it severely limits the oxygen available and can have fatal results. For young babies, the sheet and blanket should be tucked in at the bottom of the mattress and not reach any further than their armpits.

3.1 Safe Sleeping Environment for Kids.



- Baby's sleep area is in the same room, next to where you sleep.
- Use a firm and flat sleep surface, such as a mattress in a safety-approved crib, covered by a fitted sheet.
- Baby should not sleep in an adult bed, on a couch, or on a chair alone, with you, or with anyone else.
- Do not smoke or let anyone else smoke around the baby.
- Do not put pillows, blankets, sheepskins, or crib bumpers anywhere in the baby's sleep area. Keep soft objects, toys, and loose bedding out of your baby's sleep area. Make sure nothing covers the baby's head.
- Dress the baby in sleep clothing, such as a wearable blanket. Do not use a loose blanket, and do not over bundle.
- Always place the baby on his or her back to sleep, for naps and at night to reduce the Risk of **Sudden Infant Death Syndrome (SIDS)** and Other Sleep-Related Causes of Infant Death.

3.2 Sleeping Schedules for Babies

When the baby is about 2 months old, her internal clock will become a bit more predictable — and you can try implementing a basic newborn sleep schedule.

Between 3 and 6 months, the baby's bedtime, naptime and wake times will increasingly happen around the same times each day. You'll learn to anticipate the baby's natural sleepy times and work toward putting her down while she's drowsy but still awake, teaching her the valuable life skill of how to fall asleep on her own.

Keep in mind that baby sleep training in any form (also known as sleep teaching or self-soothing training) should wait until the baby is at least 4 to 6 months old, if you decide to do it at all.

The following tips can help ease your baby into a regular sleep schedule:

- **Start early but not too soon.** Newborn babies can't follow a sleep schedule, but it's possible to implement a loose eating and sleep timetable once your baby is 2 months old based on her personality and snoozing habits.
- **Become familiar with the baby's sleep patterns and "wake windows."** Keep a sleep log to get an idea of when your baby usually sleeps so you can schedule naps and bedtime accordingly, and keep track of her "wake windows," or the amounts of time babies can handle being awake, which vary by age. For example, newborns are only truly awake and alert for about three minutes of every hour, 1-month-olds for about an hour at a time and 3-month-olds for up to two hours at a stretch. And remember, all babies are different.
- **Be flexible.** When it comes to implementing routines, your baby may prefer things highly planned or more go-with-the-flow. Try to adjust your baby's sleep schedule accordingly, sticking to her natural rhythms as much as possible.
- **Watch for sleep cues.** Keep an eye out for cues that your baby is tired, like eye-rubbing, yawning or crankiness. The goal is to put your baby down when she's drowsy but not yet asleep, so she has a chance to learn how to fall asleep without help from you. If the drowsy drop-off doesn't work just yet, keep trying!
- **Follow a pre-sleep routine.** Routines are reassuring to babies and reinforce natural circadian rhythms, signaling that it's time to go to sleep. A good baby bedtime routine

might include a feeding with cuddles, bath, book, massage and lullaby. Abbreviate that routine (include just a book or a lullaby, for example) before naptime.

- **Incorporate a schedule throughout the rest of your day.** Babies feel comforted by the additional structure and rhythm of a rough daytime schedule, including the same waking time, nap times, feeding times and play times. A daytime routine can even make bedtime go smoother. You might want to wake up in the morning with cuddles and a feed, followed by a walk in the stroller or carrier. After your baby's afternoon nap, it's tummy time and babbles in the rocker.
- **Don't jump at the first noise.** Once babies are about 3 months old, they're capable of self-soothing, so don't jump to pick up your baby if she fusses during the night or during naps. Instead, wait a few minutes to see if she can fall back asleep on her own. If she continues fussing, try to check on her without picking her up.
- **Adjust as needed.** Remember that kids aren't predictable, so your baby's sleep schedule will evolve with time. A little trial and error can help you figure out what works for your baby.

3.3 Tips to Help Children Sleep

- Lower evening stimulation, by avoiding active play.
- Follow consistent, predictable routines when bathing, brushing teeth, or reading books.
- Start the bedtime process a little earlier each night, gradually getting to the desired time.
- Match the families' methods as much as possible, at least at first. The more familiar the routine, the easier it will be for everyone.
- Put children down before they are completely asleep to help them learn to self-comfort when they awake mid-nap or at nighttime.
- Darken the room, keep voices and noise down.
- Offer children a transitional or security object (e.g., a teddy bear or a blanket).
- Play soft lullabies or soothing classical music.
- Stroke or pat children softly.
- Use a nightlight if the children are afraid of the dark.